



Computing Convergence

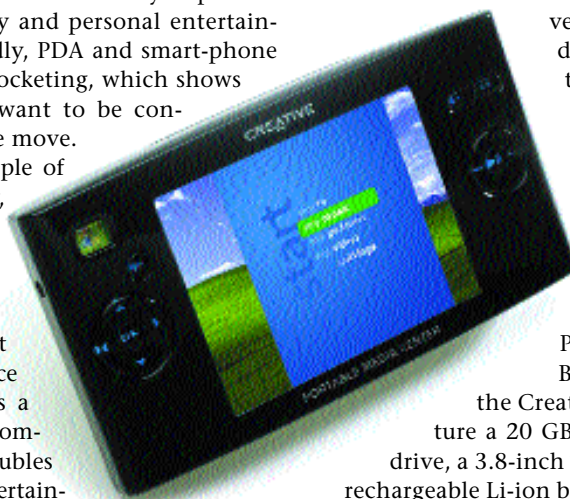
How long will it take for every device we own to be able to communicate with each other?

It had to happen, of course. Over the past couple of years, all the hype about bringing computers 'closer' to you has led companies to realise a couple of things. First, the PC is a very important part of family and personal entertainment. Secondly, PDA and smart-phone sales are skyrocketing, which shows that people want to be connected on the move.

For a couple of years now, shelling out big money for high-end PDAs will get you a device that works as a handheld computer and doubles up as an entertainment device—playing music and videos from flash memory. Now, it's getting even better. Devices, such as the Archos AV380 Jukebox, come with full-fledged 80 GB drives, a large clear screen and the ability to play hours of high quality MPEG-4 video, or DivX movies. For example, Sony's VAIO Pocket, with an inbuilt 20 GB drive and a 320x256 LCD display can store all your music and even display your pictures. The Thought personal video player with a 20 GB hard drive can give you three hours of non-stop movie playback.

Add a camera, and it becomes a personal camera recorder; add an adapter, and you can rip video straight from a VCR. Needless to say, you could also enjoy hundreds of hours of music in several compressed formats, or store thousands of pictures.

Even the big boys have got into the act—Microsoft's Portable Media Centre idea has been eagerly adopted by the likes of Creative. At CES2004 the Creative Zen Portable Media Center received rave reviews, and won the Best of CES award. Bill Gates featured it in his keynote address as well.



So what does it offer? Portable Media Centers are designed to give you easy access to video, music and pictures on the go. You can add album art, playlists, content ratings...the works. The really interesting thing is OS compatibility—all versions of Windows XP support the Media Center Edition. You'll also get the familiar Microsoft interface—though it's the Portable Media Center Platform edition.

Beyond the hype, the Creative Zen will feature a 20 GB or greater hard drive, a 3.8-inch TFT colour LCD, rechargeable Li-ion batteries and support for most audio, video and image formats. Convergence? It's already here! Keep an eye open for the Zen Portable Media Center device, releasing soon.



PEOPLE TO WATCH

Watch *Lord of Rings: Return of the King*, as you wait in the admission queue, or visit an Apple store to create a home movie. Sounds farfetched? If Steve Jobs has his way, then that day isn't far away. iTunes and the iPod have revolutionised the global music industry. Jobs has moved beyond computers, and now thinks of a converging digital world.

Steve Jobs
CEO, APPLE COMPUTER



High-Definition-Television

While digital television delivers a picture that is clear and sharp, without the reception problems associated with analog TV, High-definition Television (HDTV) offers you the best in both visual and audio quality.

The NTSC format's resolution of 480 x 440 (2,11,200 pixels) is miniscule in comparison to HDTV's resolution of 1,920 x 1,080 (20,73,600 pixels)—nearly 10 times the resolution.

Television networks select particular Digital Television (DTV) formats, used by their respective networks to transmit HDTV broadcasts. The data is transmitted by digitising and

compressing the images, which are then decompressed when they reach the TV.

Though HDTV offers better-than-DVD quality moving images, it hasn't made much of an impact on the consumer segment, primarily because of price barriers. Let's hope that changes soon, so we can really being to enjoy our movies.

